

HUNG HOUSE

are likely to throw up another fractured verdict with no clear winner even this time around



■ By Stephen David

Karnataka has seen some strange election campaigns and even stranger candidates in the past, but the impending Assembly elections are setting new benchmarks not just as far as campaigns are concerned, but even in the process of selection of candidates. Try digesting this: the Gowda clan, the Congress believes, is wary of women, more so after former prime minister and JD(S) chief H.D. Deve Gowda was defeated by television anchor and political greenhorn Tejaswini Sriramesh in the 2004 elections in the family's backyard of Kanakapura. The Congress strategy, therefore, for the elections hinges on pitting two women candidates against Gowda's two sons. It has zeroed in on Mamata Nichani, daughter of former chief minister Ramakrishna Hedge to take on H.D. Kumaraswamy, while another woman candidate, G.S. Anupama, will take on his brother H.D. Revanna. The three-phase state assembly elections in May will have over 800 candidates in the fray.

Oddities aside, it does not require help from rocket science experts to decipher the political scene in the run up to the three-phase polls that will elect the 224-strong state Assembly. The Congress, which is already exercising its influence in the Raj Bhavan here, is hoping to continue its hold on the state in the wake of a fractured

STARTING GUN:
Yeddyurappa of
the BJP remains
the front runner in
a crowded field

In the 2004 Assembly polls, the BJP had emerged the single largest party, **WINNING 79 SEATS**, a huge jump from the 44 it had won in 1999